

Business networking can tremendously increase your reach, improving results. But overdoing it can reduce your productivity for the day

Despite all the encouraging hype, some web sites even consider it to be a productivity killer. After all, beware anything addictive

Increasing productivity

Conan the Barbarian is historic. Slogging it now, is not the modern way of working but just an indication of ineffective planning. Planning well would let you unwind with a free mind and party even harder

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From being buried

When was the last time work drove you crazy? You probably hoped you didn't have to do all that work dumped on you because of a dogged list of unattended tasks. You may probably be the nicest person around who is slogging day and night without getting anywhere. You must be chaffing when all the *prigs* in office are busy planning their nights of enjoyment with their higher-ups in praise for them. Life is so unfair, or so you think. Feel left out? Someone's whining.

...Desperate times...

...Call for desperate measures. The problem lies deep within. Something's not right in the way we approach the task. "But there's so much to do, so much to remember", "I have only two hands and one brain". Empires wouldn't have been built if these reasons were valid. There ought to be a way out of the mess we've landed ourselves in to. The first thing you need to do clean all the muddiness around. Identify your strengths first, so you can bank on them to have courage. Also, work on your developmental areas. It's time to say no to IMs, social networking or streaming music - if that's what hampers productivity. Once you've identified the problem areas, the next step is to work towards improvement.

Among the most common areas of improvement are organising, time management, efficiency and communication.

Relief. But how?

Of all self-improvement terminologies sworn by, the four quadrant method is one of the most popular. According to Dr. Stephen Covey (author of *First things first*), you can classify all your tasks in to four quadrants depending on their urgency and importance. Depending upon priority, tasks are arranged into four quadrants as – I-Important and Urgent, II-Important but not urgent,

III-Not important but urgent, and IV-Not important and not urgent. Wisdom is in prioritising it rightly.

While an assignment may be important but not really urgent (quadrant II) in the morning, it could very well be important and urgent by evening (quadrant I)! According to Covey, highly effective people live in quadrant two and as a result of their efficient way of execution and planning have time to do their tasks at ease with no pressure or stress whatsoever. What he literally meant is although they stay on the pan, they never step into fire.

Once you've identified the pattern of your life by analysing it in a way similar to that mentioned in the box, you can use several tools to make it easier for you. One of the most common tool is a calendar. A good start is iCalendar Lite. To download it, go to www.tinyurl.com/icl0910. Install the executable. Once you're done, launch iCalendar. You'll have a calendar on your desktop. Right-click on the calendar to add events and tasks. This way you can keep track of all tasks you need to do and live in quadrant II. You can export calendar files from Outlook or even Google calendar (ICL files) and use them in iCalendar Lite. There is no end to the number of software available that track your time for you. But what use are they if all you are going to do is figure out using them. Outlook 2007 has a powerful calendar feature in case your company uses Outlook.

If you're continuously on the move, and switch computers often, then using time management or organising software may not be in good order. From the infamous Mumbai *dabbawallahs* to corporate heads, organising, planning and prioritising tasks can vary from a smear of paint, to scribbling on a spirally bound notepad to even PDAs, laptops and the cloud. As with Google services, login to Calendar with your Google id. Enter all the tasks for the day at the expected time. You can enter a task such as "Start preparing report at 4 pm" and set reminder as SMS and email. This way you're reminded of your task even while on the move, probably when you are on a tea break whiling away time. To top it up, this service is free. You are not charged for SMS reminders.

